Emine Kübra Usta

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EDUCATION

PhD in Economics · University of Bologna, Bologna · April 2020
Dissertation: Essays in Applied and Labor Economics
Advisor: Prof. Margherita Fort

MA in Economics · Boğaziçi University, Istanbul · August 2016
Dissertation: Effects of Compulsory Schooling Reforms on Women's Status in the Family
Advisor: Prof. Murat G. Kırdar

BA in Economics (Honors) · Boğaziçi University, Istanbul · June 2013

ACADEMIC EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant · Istanbul University, Department of Economics · October 2014–Present

Research Project Assistant · Boğaziçi University, Department of Economics · January–September 2014

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

2025 · Prolonged Guesthood: How Syrian Refugees Shaped Turkish Politics?.
Economics & Politics 37, 638–652. With E. Erbay
https://doi.org/10.1111/ecpo.12332

2023 · Factors Affecting Negative Attitudes towards Covid-19 Vaccines.
İnsan & Toplum 13(1), 53–72. With V. Bozkurt, N. B. Arlı, N. C. İlhan, B. Budak, M. A. Dev
https://doi.org/10.12658/m0674

2022 · Effects of Refugee Inflow on the Voting Behavior of Natives: Application of Mobile Phone Data.
CESifo Economic Studies 68(3), 219–252.
https://doi.org/10.1093/cesifo/ifac007

2020 · Effects of Maternal Education on Early Nonmonetary Investments in Child Development.
Journal of Human Capital 14(4), 535–585.
https://doi.org/10.1086/711761

WORK IN PROGRESS

Refugees, Local Elections, and Distributive Politics: Evidence from an Upper-Middle-Income Country

This paper examines how Syrian refugee inflows affect local election outcomes in Turkey and whether fiscal adjustments at the municipal and central-government levels help explain these effects. Using a province-level panel covering local election years from 2009 to 2024, I combine municipal council vote shares, refugee intensity, and budget composition measures. To address the endogenous spatial distribution of refugees, I employ a distance-based instrumental-variable strategy. Results show that at the national level, refugee intensity has no statistically significant average effect on local electoral outcomes. This aggregate pattern, however, masks substantial heterogeneity: in metropolitan provinces, higher refugee intensity is associated with increased support for the incumbent AKP, whereas in non-metropolitan provinces the relationship is negligible. Fiscal evidence helps explain this divergence. In metropolitan areas, refugee intensity shifts municipal spending away from goods and services toward capital expenditures and capital transfers; in smaller cities, the pattern is reversed. A similar divergence emerges at the central-government level as well. These findings suggest that the electoral politics of refugee inflows in Turkey vary with local institutional context and are accompanied by spatially differentiated fiscal responses.

Higher Education Expansion and Women Empowerment in Turkey (with E. Erbay and M. G. Kırdar)

RESEARCH GRANTS / FUNDED PROJECTS

TÜBİTAK 3501 Project: Voting Behavior in Local Elections: The Impact of Syrian Refugees in Türkiye.
Principal Investigator · Scientific and Technological Research Council of Türkiye · 2024–2026

CONFERENCES AND WORKSHOPS

• 5th RUCAM Political Economy Workshop · Nijmegen, Netherlands · August 2026 (listed as planned in source CV; paper presentation)

• Spring Meeting of Turkish Economic Association · Istanbul, Türkiye · May 2026 (paper presentation)

• Virtual PhD Workshop on Causal Analyses of School Reforms, ifo Center for the Economics of Education · October 2020 (paper presentation)

• Understanding Voluntary and Forced Migration: Research and Data Needs · Lille, France · April 2019 (paper presentation)

• 11th PhD Workshop of Collegio Carlo Alberto & University of Turin · Turin, Italy · December 2018 (paper presentation)

• Warsaw International Economic Meeting · Warsaw, Poland · July 2018 (paper presentation)

• $(Ce)^2$ Workshop · Warsaw, Poland · July 2018 (paper presentation)

• IX IBEO Workshop: Health Economics · Alghero, Italy · June 2018 (paper presentation)

• Inaugural Baltic Economic Conference · Vilnius, Lithuania · June 2018 (paper presentation)

• 1st European Causal Inference Meeting · Florence, Italy · April 2018 (poster presentation)

SEMINARS & PROFESSIONAL TRAINING

• 17th Summer School in International and Development Economics, Household Labor Markets and Development: a Structural Approach · Gargnano, Italy · September 2018 (full scholarship)

• Advanced Methods Impact Evaluation · IRVAP Winter School · Trento, Italy · January 2018

• Applied Student Education Program · Istanbul Stock Exchange · Istanbul, Türkiye · January 2013

REFEREE SERVICE

Economics of Education Review; European Economic Review; BMC Public Health; Humanities and Social Sciences Communications; Health: An Interdisciplinary Journal for the Social Study of Health, Illness and Medicine; Discover Public Health.

HONORS & AWARDS

PhD Scholarship · University of Bologna · 2016

Honors Certificate · Boğaziçi University, Faculty of Economics and Administrative Sciences · 2013

COMPUTER SKILLS & LANGUAGES

Tools: Microsoft Office, LaTeX, Stata, MATLAB

Languages: Turkish (native); English (fluent); German (beginner); Arabic (beginner)